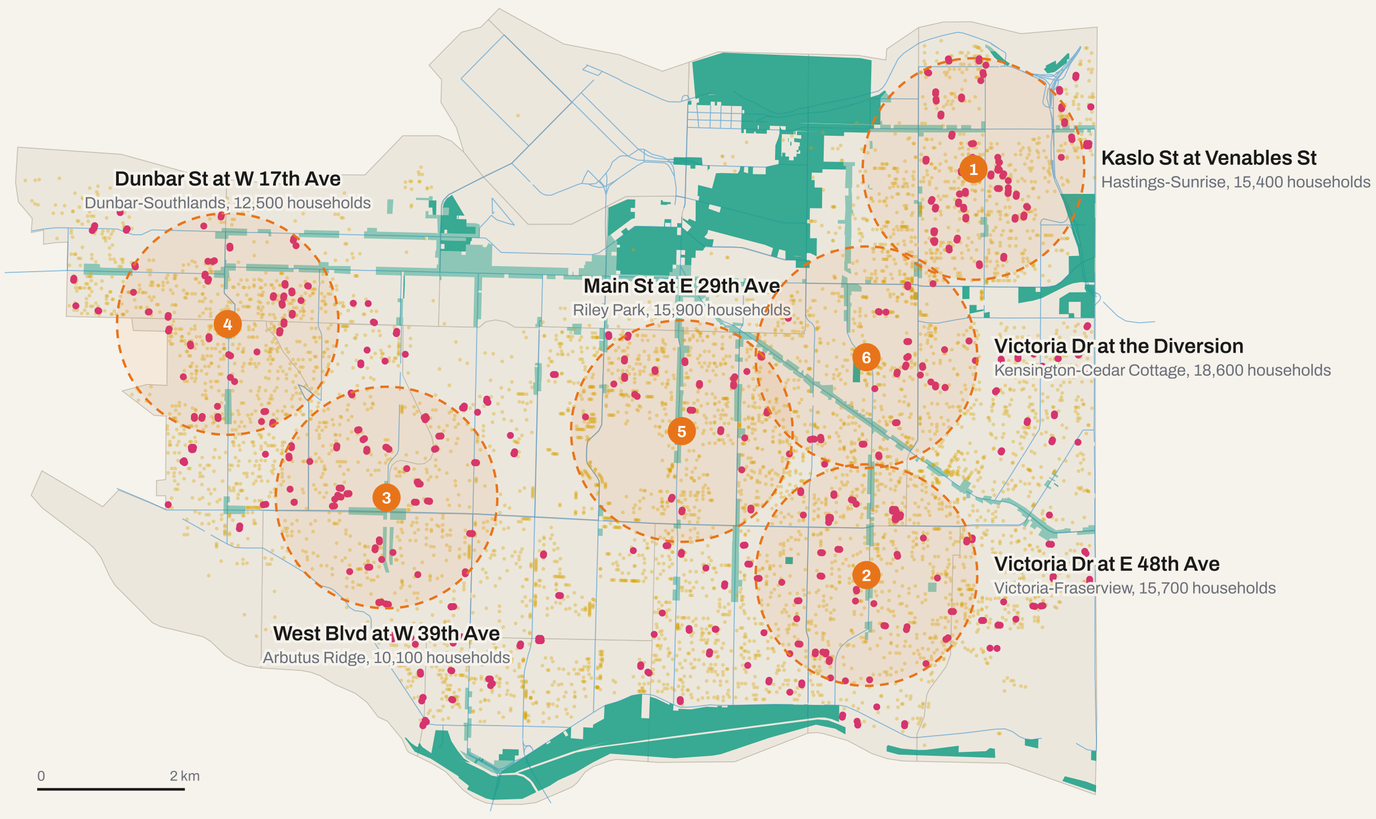
Where hubs go

Hubs go where houses come down and multiplexes go up, on land a workshop could use beside a truck route. Four stated rules place six sites, and six is roughly what the city's pace of demolition would keep busy.



87,500 households within the six rings

57% of house demolitions within 1.5 km

63% of new multiplexes within 1.5 km

Key

- house demolitions, 2017–2026
- new multiplexes, since June 2024
- land a workshop could use, by a truck route
- hub site and 1.5 km ring, about a 20-minute walk

The answer, in brief

Six sites, chosen one at a time by how many house demolitions and new multiplexes each brings within a twenty-minute walk, each on commercial or industrial land within 200 m of a truck route. Their rings hold 57% of house demolitions since 2017, 63% of new multiplexes, and about 87,500 households, 29% of the city's.

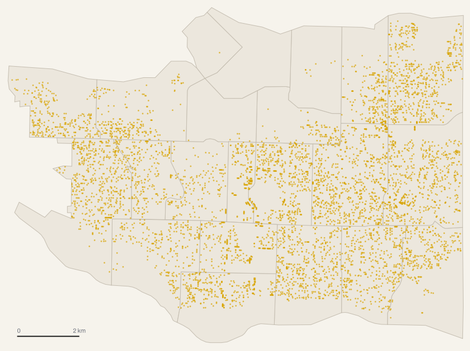
The first round placed five hubs at the centres of demolition clusters: 0 of 5 on land a workshop could use, reaching 50% of house demolitions and 43% of new multiplexes. The rules do better on both, with a median haul of 1.4 km.

What this is not

Candidates produced by rules, not selected properties. No parcel, owner, price or lot size has been checked, and every site would still need a rezoning or a conditional approval. The capacity figures behind the number six are hypotheses to test.

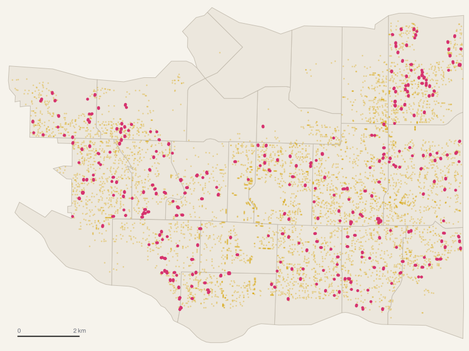
How the six were found: four rules

A hub takes in houses as large panels and offers their parts to the next buildings. So it should sit where houses come down and homes are being built, on land that can hold a workshop and a public building, by a road trucks may use.



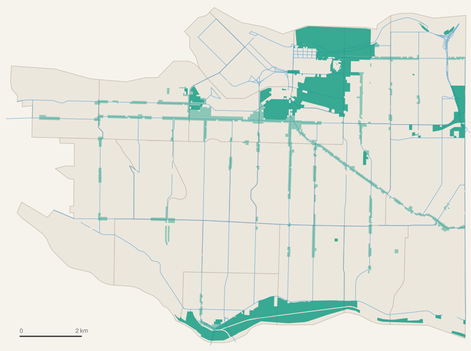
1 Where houses come down

6,236 demolition permits for one- and two-family houses, 2017 to October 2026: the house neighbourhoods, east and south.



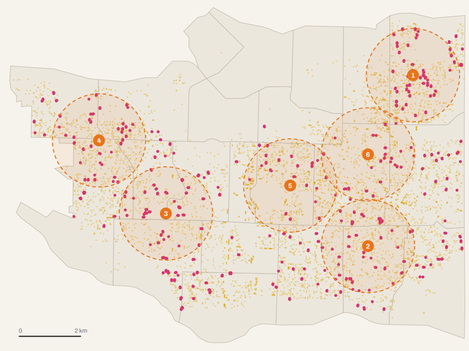
2 Where multiplexes go up

616 new-building permits naming a multiplex, over the houses: the same streets, so one's parts could go to the other.



3 Land a workshop could use

Industrial zones (I, M, IC, MC, dark) and commercial arterials (C-2 family and C-3A, light), only within 200 m of a City truck route (blue).



4 One at a time

From 4,089 candidate cells of 50 m, each hub goes where it adds the most not-yet-covered houses and multiplexes within 1.5 km, as equal shares.

Who and what each ring holds

1 Kaslo St at Venables St

Hastings-Sunrise, zone M-1
140 m to a truck route

15,400 households

- 592 house demolitions
- 89 new multiplexes
- 0.7 km to Hastings community centre
- none rapid transit stations in the ring
- 1 City-owned property within 400 m

Hastings-Sunrise 81%, Grandview-Woodland 19%

2 Victoria Dr at E 48th Ave

Victoria-Fraserview, zone C-2A
30 m to a truck route

15,700 households

- 655 house demolitions
- 67 new multiplexes
- 1.5 km to Kensington community centre
- none rapid transit stations in the ring
- 0 City-owned properties within 400 m

Victoria-Fraserview 57%, Kensington-Cedar Cottage 18%, Sunset 15%

3 West Blvd at W 39th Ave

Arbutus Ridge, zone C-2A
10 m to a truck route

10,100 households

- 388 house demolitions
- 87 new multiplexes
- 0.4 km to Kerrisdale community centre
- none rapid transit stations in the ring
- 5 City-owned properties within 400 m

Kerrisdale 39%, Arbutus Ridge 31%, Shaughnessy 22%

4 Dunbar St at W 17th Ave

Dunbar-Southlands, zone C-2A
0 m to a truck route

12,500 households

- 583 house demolitions
- 67 new multiplexes
- 1.6 km to Dunbar community centre
- none rapid transit stations in the ring
- 4 City-owned properties within 400 m

Dunbar-Southlands 40%, Kitsilano 26%, West Point Grey 25%

5 Main St at E 29th Ave

Riley Park, zone C-2A
30 m to a truck route

15,900 households

- 724 house demolitions
- 41 new multiplexes
- 0.5 km to Hillcrest community centre
- 1 rapid transit station in the ring
- 11 City-owned properties within 400 m

Riley Park 68%, Kensington-Cedar Cottage 19%

6 Victoria Dr at the Diversion

Kensington-Cedar Cottage, zone C-2A
22 m to a truck route

18,600 households

- 613 house demolitions
- 43 new multiplexes
- 0.2 km to Trout Lake community centre
- 2 rapid transit stations in the ring
- 6 City-owned properties within 400 m

Kensington-Cedar Cottage 64%, Renfrew-Collingwood 20%

Why six

hubs = share of houses taken × houses demolished a year ÷ houses one hub can take apart a year

Houses a year. 678 one- and two-family demolition permits a year on average, 2022–2025 (2022: 859, 2023: 582, 2024: 570, 2025: 703): about thirteen a week.

One hub's year. Cornell's Circular Construction Lab took one Ithaca house apart in 447.5 labour hours on site and 96 off site. I assume a hub moves about two thirds of the total, 360 hours, off site. A crew of 12 at 1,700 productive hours each then takes apart about 57 houses a year, about one a week.

Share. Half the houses, as a working target: some will still be demolished, and some taken apart on site by firms that already do it.



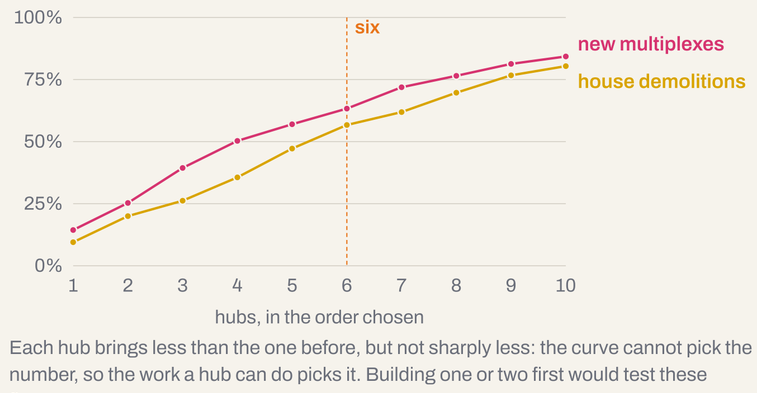
A week of house demolitions; orange, what six hubs could take apart.

How far six moves, when each assumption changes

share	crew 8 250 h	crew 8 360 h	crew 8 450 h	crew 12 250 h	crew 12 360 h	crew 12 450 h	crew 16 250 h	crew 16 360 h	crew 16 450 h
25%	3.1	4.5	5.6	2.1	3.0	3.7	1.6	2.2	2.8
50%	6.2	9.0	11.2	4.2	**6.0**	7.5	3.1	4.5	5.6
75%	9.3	13.5	16.8	6.2	9.0	11.2	4.7	6.7	8.4

Hubs needed, by share of houses taken (rows), crew size and off-site hours a house (columns); base case highlighted. 678 houses a year, 1,700 hours a worker.

Reach, as hubs are added in order



Each hub brings less than the one before, but not sharply less: the curve cannot pick the number, so the work a hub can do picks it. Building one or two first would test these figures.

What a hub also offers its neighbours

A multiplex turns one household into as many as eight, but adds no shared room. Each hub could add rooms along its street, and teach the work it does. First thoughts on the programme, not a layout.

- **café and grocery** daily visits
- **plaza and court** open space
- **culture and exhibition** the parts' stories
- **a classroom** learning by watching the work
- **gather, analyse, unbuild, sort, offer** the deconstruction itself

Limits

Straight lines, not road routes; real hauls are longer.

Permits read from free text, so counts are a floor; a permit records a demolition, not what was recovered.

Households from 2021, spread evenly over each dissemination area; the multiplexes since are not counted.

The capacity figures are mine, resting on one house in Ithaca, not on Vancouver practice.

Zoning is a proxy, not a permitted-use check; C-2 lots are shallow, so a hub there needs lots assembled or City land.

Equal weight to houses and multiplexes; weighting supply would pull the chain east.

What comes next

Site and Program, 18 November: choose the first hub; check parcels, ownership and City land near it; set programme areas.

Progress Review 2, 2 December: follow three houses into multiplexes near it, and test the off-site share against what I observe.

GP II: design the first hub on that site, from parts the catalogue finds.

Sources and method

City of Vancouver open data, fetched 24–26 Oct 2026: building permits (demolition since 2017; new buildings naming a multiplex since June 2024), zoning, truck routes, community centres, rapid transit, City-owned properties, local areas. Statistics Canada, 2021 Census by dissemination area. Heisel et al., Cornell Circular Construction Lab, 2023. Method: build/hub_siting.py; candidate cells of 50 m; households on a 10 m grid; greedy maximum coverage within 1.5 km, houses and multiplexes as equal shares.